



Did you know?

Will Smith turned down the roll of Neo from the Matrix, in favour of the Wild Wild West!

A chat with virus warriors

We spent a day talking with Mark Kanok and John Harrison, Symantec's crusaders against the war on malware.

d The mobile security market is still in its infancy, when do you think smartphone users would start taking mobile threats as seriously as threats from PC?

Imagine a thousand dollars strapped to your body – our mobile devices have become like that because of the banking capabilities that you have along with other personal information on the device. It's an evolution, primarily because of the things people are doing with their devices mobile security is something which shouldn't be optional any more.

d Would we soon see mobile devices shipping with pre loaded security apps?



Mark Kanok
Consumer product
management
mobile, Symantec

It's already happening, there are a number of different partners we are working with. People may want to choose their mobile security the way they do with their PC security. There are a lot of vendors that are taking different approaches at this time. People have already started taking mobile security pretty seriously.

d Where do you see the tablet market heading in terms of security apps and features?

Tablets are an interesting angle and Norton mobile security works in the tablet mode. We've adjusted the UI to work and accommodate the larger form

factor. With tablets you see similar type of activities – people are either browsing on the internet or they are downloading apps to play. So the same security features are applied. Our goal is to make sure people download safe things and also they don't lose their device.

d How long does it take before an infected app is discovered on the Android market?

Apps try to go by in a pretty undetectable fashion, but we keep looking at things on constant basis. We have a number of capabilities such as mobile insight capabilities to evaluate and assess hundreds and thousands of different apps. Looking at apps which are malicious is a little bit tougher as there are couple of different types of layers involved. There are permissions that are requested to one's that are actually utilised if there is a submission of personal information somewhere in a disguised fashion. All these things come into play to assess things if they are dangerous or not. **d**

John Harrison Group product manager, Symantec

d Whenever there is a virus outbreak what is the first thing that Norton researches do? There are a variety of outbreaks, what our researches are doing is understanding when new vulnerabilities are announced. We have a team set up that is tearing apart and understanding the implications of a vulnerability in an operating system or a third party plug in. If there is malware that is reaching certain parts of the world, we'll understand and see whether we have protection in place or whether we need to update the existing protection out in the field. We're looking at keeping up and understanding what is the malware actually doing and making sure that we stay ahead of the curve and understand the methods of what we need to do to detect the new malware that's put there.

d Can you tell us about the new sonar technology used in Norton products?

The sonar technology is really exciting because rather than focusing on the file finger prints which may change all

the time, what it does is that it analyses and looks at behaviour of the malware or programs when they execute. So what we've done is first started with all applications that are running on a system and characterise what good applications do and what bad applications do. Along with this, there's machine learning and analysis to see what good or bad programs do – or do they even open.

d So how's a typical malware generated?

Malware these days is dynamically generated just for you; it's not been seen by any security vendor so if you rely on waiting and then create protection, that's not going work. We had to create network intrusion program or browser protection, if we see a vulnerability being exploited it could potentially have an outbreak so

this is one of those proactive technologies. So the Insight system is based to tackle such dynamically generated threats.

d How do engineers at Norton prepare against threats?

Our insight technology not just looks at bad things, we calculate a risk and trust rating for every app executable on consumer and enterprise PCs. We have 2.5 billion files today that we've calculated under a risk or trust rating to provide a reputation score and when you download a new file that pretends to be a video player or a PDF we can look at it and say this has only been seen on one user's desktop. If it isn't

from a trusted domain and does some bad things we think it's malware, lets remove it, or we can think this has been seen on millions of user desktops this is a known good version of the applications. **d**



John Harrison
Group product
manager, Symantec